KICKING PAST BORDERS

HARSHIKA JAIN SIGNS WITH A TOP-TIER CLUB IN ROMANIA AND JOINS THE EVEN MORE EXCLUSIVE LEAGUE OF INDIAN FOOTBALLERS WITH FOREIGN CONTRACTS

There are few Indian women footballers like Ashalata Devi Loitongbam and Ngangom Bala Devi, who have plied their trade in foreign leagues. Harshika Jain joins the elite list, becoming the first Indian to play in Romania after signing for first division side, Atletic Olimpia Gherla.

The 22-year-old from Mumbai last turned out for Gokulam Kerala, winning the Indian Women's League with them in 2022-23. Mentor Varin Mehta landed her an opportunity with the Romanian club and, after a 20-day stint, she signed a one-year contract. "The coach, Mirel Albon, saw my videos and asked me to come for trials. Playing alongside players from the Romanian national team was really good," Jain says.

Jain either played with boys or older girls on the school team. Mehta took her under his wing in the 9th grade, grooming her into a nippy striker. Her family encouraged her to turn professional and she played for Mumbai-based clubs, PIFA Colaba and Kenkre FC, besides the Maharashtra team for a while.

"I put in a lot of work during my teens when most of my friends were having fun. In fact, my coach and I took on a brutal training regime during the pandemic, which transformed me into a much stronger player," she says.

Jain has picked up a smattering of Romanian to aid her on the pitch. The dream is to finish top scorer in the domestic league, qualify for the Champions League, and make the cut on the national side that will play the AFC Asian Cup next year. ■

—Shail Desai

> Jain used to play with boys or older girls, **a coach took her under his wing** and groomed her into a nippy striker



BEND IT LIKE HARSHIKA The 22-year-old cites a "brutal training regime" in the pandemic for her wins

▼ **AYUSH SHETTY, 20**
Badminton

A FATEFUL DROP

In February 2024, Ayush Shetty was ranked outside the top 100 of the world. Mixed results marked most of the year, with a couple of third-place finishes and quarter-final appearances. His results followed a similar pattern this year, until he struck gold at the US Open in June—his first title on the Badminton World Federation Tour. Ironically, Shetty has still to win a senior level tournament at the national level. But that should hardly matter for the second-highest ranked Indian in the world.



◀ **ANIMESH KUJUR, 22**
Athletics

SHARPLY TO THE TOP

Shattering records has become routine for Animesh Kujur this year. In April, he registered a new national record in the 200 metres at the Federation Cup, and bettered it when he won a bronze at the Asian Athletics Championship the next month. In between the two events, he annexed the 4x100m national record. This month, he became the fastest Indian after registering 10.18 seconds in the 100 metres in Greece.

—Compiled by Shail Desai